Research Objective

One major objective of the project is to identify a Customer Relationship Management (CRM) system capable of supporting VPEd's complex workflow: tracking universities, students, supervisors, patients, sessions, outcomes, and compliance-related data. The goal of this Phase 3 research was to determine whether Salesforce's platform architecture, automation tools, and security features align with VPEd's operational needs and long-term growth strategy.

Research Process

Research consisted of analyzing Salesforce documentation, reviewing best-practice CRM implementations for healthcare-adjacent organizations, and mapping VPEd's program workflow onto Salesforce data structures. Additional comparisons were made between native Salesforce capabilities (custom objects, automation, permission sets) and VPEd's required processes for student matching, scheduling, and feedback collection.

Key Findings

1. **Object Structure Supports VPEd's Data Model**
    a. *Accounts* can represent universities, allowing tracking of program status (prospect, contacted, demo scheduled, pilot, active, renewal, inactive).
    b. *Contacts* can store student and supervisor records.
    c. *Custom Objects* can model VPEd-specific needs, including:
        - Patients
        - Sessions
        - Matches (student-to-patient matching)
        - Feedback

    This structure supports relational data, reporting, and oversight.

2. **Custom Fields Enable Clinical Education Workflows**
    a. Student status picklist values can track progress: inquiry, applied, qualified, awaiting match, matched, scheduled, completed.
    b. University lifecycle stages can map to recruitment, engagement, and renewal.

3. **Reports for Operational Visibility**

    Salesforce can generate key dashboards such as:
    a. Students by status
    b. Students awaiting match
    c. Active universities
    d. Sessions completed

These dashboards give staff real-time insight into bottlenecks, caseloads, and program capacity.

4. **Automation Improves Efficiency (Flow Builder)**

   Automated workflows can reduce manual workload and ensure consistent communication:

   a. When a student becomes "qualified," Salesforce can automatically create a *Match Review* task for staff.
   b. When a session is marked "completed," Salesforce can automatically send a feedback survey.
   c. When a university enters "pilot," the system can notify the team for onboarding.
   d. If a student remains in "awaiting match" for 7+ days, Salesforce can alert an administrator to intervene.

   Automation supports VPEd's need for timely pairing and accurate tracking.

5. **Security & HIPAA Awareness**

   Although Salesforce is not inherently HIPAA-compliant unless paired with the proper edition and Business Associate Agreement (BAA), the platform allows for detailed security controls through:

   a. Profiles
   b. Permission sets
   c. Field-level security

      These tools help define:

      - Who can view patient data
      - Who can export data
      - Who can edit clinical session records
      - Who can see supervisor notes

   This aligns with VPEd's need to protect patient identity and maintain compliance.

6. **Feedback Collection Can Be Systematized**

   Salesforce supports a custom Feedback object with fields such as:

   a. Related session
   b. Student rating
   c. Patient rating
   d. Supervisor rating
   e. Testimonial (with review/approval)

This structure allows VPEd to gather outcome data to support quality improvement and marketing efforts.

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